Keeping Bees in the City

Campus Garden Society

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Abstract

Honey bees are surprisingly well suited to city life. This short article explains why urban gardens need pollinators, what a beginner needs before the first hive arrives, and how to run a safe first inspection.

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1 Introduction

A single hive on a rooftop can visit flowers up to three kilometres away. Parks, street trees and balcony gardens bloom at different times, so city bees often find food for longer than bees on farms that grow one crop.

Beekeeping is also a quiet hobby. A healthy colony needs about half an hour of attention every week during spring and summer, and almost none in winter.

2 Why Bees Matter

2.1 Pollination

About one third of the food we eat depends on pollinators. Bees move pollen from flower to flower while they collect nectar, and many fruit trees give a much

smaller harvest without them.

2.2 Honey and Wax

A strong colony can store more honey than it needs. The beekeeper takes only the surplus[1] and the wax caps that cover it, which can be melted into candles.

3 Getting Started

3.1 Choosing a Site

Place the hive where the entrance faces away from paths and doors. A fence or a hedge in front of the entrance makes the bees fly up and over the heads of people nearby.

3.2 Equipment

3.2.1 Protective Clothing

A veil and a pair of gloves are enough for most beginners. A full suit is useful on hot days, when bees are more defensive.

3.2.2 Hive Tools

A smoker calms the bees, and a flat hive tool lifts the frames apart. Both are cheap and last for many years.

3.3 The First Inspection

Open the hive on a warm, calm afternoon when most bees are out foraging. Look for eggs, larvae and stored food, then close the hive within ten minutes.

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[1] Leave at least 15 kg of honey in the hive for the winter.